Instead, they only ‘make a thousand foolish and confused observations’. He is bemused by their conception of the world as an illusion, and has no patience for their ‘fine similes’. ‘In vain will you look for any solid answer,’ he declares.

He asks the six learned pandits of Varanasi for ‘their opinion of the adoration of idols’. The pandits respond, ‘Images are admitted in our temples, because we conceive that prayers are offered up with more devotion where there is something before the eyes that fixes the mind; but in fact we acknowledge that God alone is absolute, that He only is the omnipotent Lord.’ Bernier doubts this explanation. He suspects ‘it was so framed as to correspond with the tenets of Christianity. The observations made to me by other learned Pendets were totally different’. He needles another set of Brahmins that many of their practices aren’t possible in colder climes, such as bathing in rivers, clearly showing that their religion is not universal—and therefore inferior. But the Brahmins see things differently:

> ‘We pretend not,’ they replied, ‘that our law is of universal application. God intended it only for us, and this is the reason why we cannot receive a foreigner into our religion. We do not even say that yours is a false religion: it may be adapted to your wants and circumstances, God having, no doubt, appointed many different ways of going to heaven.’ I found it impossible to convince them that the Christian faith was designed for the whole earth, and theirs was mere fable and gross fabrication.

To the modern reader, this gives a sense of a series of frustrating engagements driven largely by Bernier’s inability to step outside his own philosophical framework. He rarely doubts his own comprehension and certainties in religion. Instead, his response is to grossly misunderstand and ridicule, and declare much of what he hears as ‘extravagant folly’. He doesn’t read Sanskrit, yet calls all of their books full of ‘fabulous trash’. In geography, he claims, ‘They believe that the world is flat and triangular.’ This would have been news to Alberuni, who came in the eleventh century, read texts in Sanskrit and characterized the Indians’ knowledge systems far more intelligently before evaluating them.

Could it be that Bernier’s views were coloured by popular beliefs and social practices—astrology, superstitions, sati, naked fakirs, otherworldly attitudes, etc.—that vexed his humanistic sensibilities, and which then led him to dismiss that entire edifice of philosophies that he saw as enablers?